Mutually Assured Destruction

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Mature

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by PlagueAngel

Summary

Double Trouble's girlfriend—and their ticket to Princess Prom—breaks up with them. Furious, they call up their "strict business partner" (dubious lesbian situationship with money exchanged) Dr. Cainabeth Rot to act as their date and make their ex jealous.

Stretched out in one long shape and draped over the couch, Double Trouble sighed, pressing the backs of their fingers against the floor. Tissues littering the wood were inches away from their nails.

“I can’t believe that bitch Devena,” they sobbed, dabbing at their closed eye with a lavender-scented tissue. Then they closed their other eyelids too. “Can’t believe her. Ruining my mascara instead of my lipstick, oh, God!” The gramophone in the corner was playing the saddest record Double Trouble had, a baritone voice crooning about love lost against a gentle violin soundtrack. They couldn’t remember which ex they’d stolen this one from.

“What a pity that she broke up with me. I can’t even remember her new girlfriend’s name, only those amazing shoes! She’s named, like, Merlot or something, God, I need a glass of that right now. I mean, honestly, the nerve. How dare she deprive me of my ticket to Princess Prom?”

In the next room, a cleaver slammed hard against a cutting board. Double Trouble flinched, quickly sitting up, hand flitting quietly to the thin knife against their thigh. Stompy bootsteps and wing flutters sounded throughout the hallway and then Cainabeth slammed open the living room door. She’d obviously thrown a scarf on, settling it hastily over her chest to cover herself. Double Trouble was beginning to get the idea that she hated shirts.

Trouble allowed tension to leave their shoulders as they tilted their head at Cainabeth, blonde hair cascading across black leather. “Well, hello, Dr. Rot. To what do I owe the pleasure?”

“I can’t believe I believed you,” The leather of Cainabeth’s gloves squeaked as her fists clenched.

“Hmm?”

“I can’t believe you cried your way in here for no good reason! You never actually cared about that girl, did you?”

“Of course not, darling, everyone knows that the only thing I care about is coin.”

“Dr. Rot, I’m so sad, let me in your house!” Cainabeth mimicked. “Let me lie on your couch and use your gramophone!”

“That is not what I said, give a more convincing performance, will you?! And besides, you haven’t even let me in your house ever, just your living roomâ€¦”

“Yeah, fucker, if you use those little lockpicks of yours I’ll eat you for breakfast. Buzz off and stop asking.”

“I didn’t ask a damn thing.”

“Well, I’m not gonna answer if you do!”

As good an opportunity as any. “Nah, I think you’re going to have to answer this oneâ€¦ wanna be my date to Princess Prom?”

“What?! No! Did I miss something? I’m pretty sure I’m not a fucking Princess! Devena was your ticket in, and you lost her, so don’t come crying to me about the consequences!” Cainabeth got all up in their face, her skin red and blotchy, studded with revolting clogged pores. Did the bitch never wash her face? Double Trouble merely gave her a smile, and watched her face change as she felt the thin knife pointed at her stomach.

“Don’t worry, it’s just symbolism, darling. I’m not really going to pull your guts out, no, that’s your prerogative, isn’t it, condor? But don’t forget that I could ruin your entire life if I wanted to, okay, baby?” They raised an eyebrow. “That being said, I’m not going to force you to go if you won’t enjoy it, but it would make me very, very happy. And don’t you want to make Mama happy?”

“Youâ€¦ are one disgusting cunt,” Cainabeth breathed, her face going redder.

“And you love it.”

“Would you expect anything different from a carrion-eater?” she smirked, putting a hand on Double Trouble’s chest. “I don’t know how you can talk like that, motherfucker, like you’ve got any power over me. I could kill you in an instant.”

“But you won’t. We have an agreement for a reason, darling.”

“That’s true.” She raised an eyebrow. At heart, Cainabeth was surely just as cold and calculating as her business partner was, despite her emotional displays. Double Trouble could see the gears in her head turning.

“Why do you even want me?”

Trouble rolled their eyes. “It’s goddamn obvious, isn’t it? I’ve got to show my ex up. Who’s the sexiest, richest, and deadliest person I know?”

Cainabeth’s face went redder with each adjective, then she turned slightly away and tucked a strand of hair behind her ear. “You could have led with that, you dumb slut,” she said, a twinge of pride in her voice.

“I knew you’d agree, darling.” I win, again.

The doctor’s eyes narrowed. “Don’t push your luck.” Careful, fucker. They held each other’s gaze for a second, before Double Trouble grabbed Cainabeth’s wrist, ignoring her stricken look. “Hey, come on, let’s go back to my place! Now I have to go plan a new outfit, my old one was to match Devena. You know what, I think I’m going to wear that coat my other ex left at my placeâ€””

â€”-

“You look divine,” Double Trouble purred, slinking their hand up Cainabeth’s arm. She rolled her eyes and muttered, “Perv,” but not without a smile.

“I adore your style, darling. Such individualism!”

“Is that supposed to be a backhanded compliment, orâ€””

“Don’t ask me things like that! Of course I would totally hire you to costume my next production.” Their fingers kept stroking Cainabeth’s arm as they felt her get warm under their touch, and they almost pressed in further, their cold blood chasing the heat.

“Fuck, I don’t know why you’re acting like I’m some sort of designer. I literally don’t care how I look.” Her long black duster had feathersâ€”her own?â€”sewn on the collar and cuffs, with slits up the back to accommodate her large wings. Begrudgingly, she’d put on a real garmentâ€”a low-cut black velvet dressâ€”underneath, although she’d refused anything sleeved, and her signature gloves remained firmly on her hands.

“Those shoes beg to differ.”

“The fuck is it with you and shoes?!” Her ears went red, and she rocked backwards on her platforms, embarrassed. They had to be at least four inches, and nearly made her as tall as Double Trouble. Nearly.

“Oh, I just appreciate fine craftsmanship when I see it.” Double Trouble tossed their hair. “At any rate, the two of us should be hot enough to make a statement.”

Cainabeth’s eyes took in their crop top, short skirt, and fur coat. She stepped closer and Trouble felt a wing settle about her shoulders. Her fingers took hold of the ring on their choker, and with a wicked smile, Double Trouble leaned in closer, their hand on her bare chestâ€”

“Aren’t you cold?” Her hand released the metal ring and pressed flat against their chest, dark leather warm against their skin.

“I’m fine,” Double Trouble lied, shoving her off of them. Cainabeth scoffed, lowering her wing slowly to fold back behind her.

“I just thought, well, fuck, you’re cold-blooded and this whole place is made of ice andâ€”I mean, your wholeâ€¦ everything’s

out.” She wouldn’t meet their eyes.

“I am fine, sweetcheeks. Do you really think I’d have as much of an impact if I covered up like you?” They made a show of looking her up and down. “I mean, you work it, butâ€””

Cainabeth bared her teeth, and Double Trouble noted a speck of gristle stuck in them. “Don’t fuck with me. I will literally bite you, bitchass.” They winced. Her breath smelled rancidâ€”they didn’t want to know what (or who) she’d eaten this morning.

“Relax. That wasn’t an insult.” They raised their hand in a placating gesture, their tail curled behind them. “Besides, you’d need to wait a couple hours for my body to start decaying in this temperature.”

Cainabeth’s hands went up to smooth her hair back. When that dark curtain pushed back over her shoulders, her tiny jawbone earrings were visible. Double Trouble didn’t understand her obsession with bonesâ€”she certainly had jewels in her inventory. Why not wear those? Her hair fell back into place quickly enough, obscuring the jewelry again.

“Whatever,” she muttered. “Go hurry up and enjoy yourself. I’m getting out of this place as soon as possibleâ€”ugh, do I have to take you home?”

“Would you be a dear?” Double Trouble batted their eyelashes.

“Fuck you.”

â€”

Trouble never let not being allowed into a place stop them. It was almost too easy to shapeshift into a Princess already past check-in, then sneak in with Cainabeth on their arm. I just came out here for a smoke, take a chill pill, Mister Guard. DT shapeshifted back while walking beneath a dark curtain. Cainabeth’s punch nearly landed on their jaw, but they pulled away.

“Are you fuckin’ stupid? Your ex is gonna rat you out if she sees you, and you’re shifting in the open like that? Dumbass.” Then her eyes narrowed. “You have shown your true form to her, right? You didn’t date her as someone else? That’d be low, even for you.”

“Oh, Dr. Rot, always assuming the worstâ€¦ she does know this look, but she won’t tattle if she knows what’s good for her. I have all the dirt on every single girl I’ve ever dated. I could ruin her.”

Cainabeth stopped walking. “... You’re terrifying and I hate that we’re friends.”

“You’re my partner in crime because you know what’s good for yourself, darling.” Double Trouble patted her on the head, to a scowl. “Now come on, we have to go find my ex.” They grabbed her arm.

“This is a horrible fuckin’ idea,” Cainabeth muttered, but followed where Double Trouble led her anyway. “What does she look like again?” she whispered, eyes scanning side to side.

“She wears a lot of purple. And spikes.”

“For a shapeshifter, you are really shit at describing people.” Cainabeth rolled her eyes.

“Oh, darling, do you really think my art is about looks? No, no, noâ€”resembling somebody means nothing if you don’t know what makes them tick. You’ve gotta get into their skin.” They fanned themself. “Just wearing someone’s face isn’t enough.”

“That’s creepy as fuck.”

Double Trouble blinked their inner eyelids, subtly checking their surroundings, then steadied their hands on Cainabeth’s shoulders under a shadowy staircase. They took a breath, then shifted to look like her.

“Gah!” This time, the blow did land. Trouble winced and shifted back into their normal form, feeling at the blue bruise on their

jaw.

“I told you not to fucking do that. That’s why you have no friends.”

“I have friends!” they scoffed, offended.

“Only when someone fucking pays you for it!”

“... Do you really think you’re any different, babe?”

She grabbed their thin wrist, and they looked at her through their lashes, unimpressed. “Oh, no. My weak little wrist. How ever will I escape you, brute!”

“I don’t fucking get why you’re not scared of me,” Cainabeth snarled, her grip tightening. “Why do you taunt meâ€”why do you push me like this?”

Double Trouble cocked their head to the side, their inner eyelids blinking sideways. “I don’t understand why you’re scared of me.”

“You collect blackmail on your exes. Is that not enough of a reason?”

“Such an ugly word! Baby, come on, it’s just my protectionâ€”you know that my line of work can be dangerous out in the Waste, hmm?” Their fingers curled, but they didn’t pull away from her grasp. “Even just the teensiest bit of dirt on my partners, it makes everything cleaner for me. Keeps things from gettingâ€¦ messy.” And of course, once they didn’t need that leverage, they always sold that information to the highest bidder. Who cared if Devena had done anything wrong? The evidence binder in their trunk was a ticking time bomb.

Cainabeth’s hand wrapped around their other wrist too and shoved them back against the icy wall of the staircase. An involuntary grunt left Trouble’s lips as she pressed their hands together above their head. “You need to get rid of everything you have on me the second you're home. I can’t believe I let it get

this far. I’m serious. Burn it. And I will watch. If you don’t, I’ll kill you right here and you’ll never make it home.” Her wings flared out behind her, extending almost out to their full span, casting Double Trouble in shadow.

Double Trouble swallowed their fear and cracked a smile, tilting their chin up. Then they started to laughâ€”genuinely. Cainabeth’s eyes twitched. “What the fuck is wrong with you?”

A slight rise of the eyebrow, a dip of the gaze, and a bite of the lipâ€”it was so easy to make Cainabeth stall, her eyes darting to their mouth. “Noâ€”fuck youâ€”” She was poised like she wanted to run. “I’m not letting you use me like that right after you break up with someoneâ€”this is an act, you’re not going toâ€”right? God, it’s the first time I’ve ever wanted anything of yours to be an actâ€””

“You know you want it.” Trouble tilted their head to the side, arching their back away from the wall. “Don’t you want to take me like this? I’m so vulnerable and helpless, aren’t I?”

“Liar,” she whispered, and it hit their spine like a thundercrack. “Don’t try to make me believe this is the real you. I can see through it, you know, sometimes I think I’m the only person that can.”

“Darling, put all that aside for a moment. All this talk about truth and whatnot. Isn’t it enough to know what we want to do with our bodies? And I think we both know what we want to do with each others’.”

Cainabeth’s face reddened, exactly as Trouble had scripted. “I want to eat you.”

“Oh, well, consumption and sex, it’s all the same to me.” Double Trouble waved their hand, flippant, even as Cainabeth’s expression changed. “Warmth, wetness, and body heatâ€”heavy breathing, sharp teethâ€”split of the gristle. Closeness, flesh inside other flesh. Just a few ideas. So romantic!”

“Now I want to eat you even more,” Cainabeth snarled, burying her face in Trouble’s neck. They winced as her teeth dragged against their jugular, one hand pressing firm against their back, chests crushed together. Her breathing rattled against Double Trouble’s ribcage. They pulled away, but her other hand pressed both their wrists against the ice wall, pushing chill into their flesh.

“Please don’t kill me before I get to humiliate my ex,” tumbled shakily from Double Trouble’s mouth. They bit their lip soon after, then when they spoke again, it was bright and teasing. “I’m too young to die!”

“Older than me,” Cainabeth muttered, but she let go of them, her hand sliding into theirs. They smiled, tilting their head in towards herâ€”but stopped when she scowled. Cainabeth hated to let go of anything.

“Don’t tell anyone my secrets or I swear to fuck, you’re getting eaten.”

Trouble pursed their lips. “Look, I don’t have anything on you.”

“I don’t buy that. There’s a great deal of people who want my position in the Waste. Not that any of those wimps fuckin’ deserve it.” She spat on the floor. “They wouldn’t want to be me anymore if they knew. There’s plenty of people hungry for my past and I’m not bringing it up to anyone ever again, so you can fuck off and burn it all.”

“I don’tâ€¦” Double Trouble hesitated, calculating. “I’m telling the truth. I couldn’t find anything on you.” Hand over chest. “Cross my heart. I would never go back on our contract.”

Cainabeth rolled her eyes. “A friendship contract is such a stupid fucking concept. This is why you don’t have any friends, you weirdo. You’re so immature.”

“I’m immature, darling? At least I don’t swear like I just discovered the words.”

“Listen here, fuckerâ€”ah, well, you got me there. Anyway, I think you’re callous and calculating and shrewd and disgusting.” Double Trouble braced for more insults, but then she said simply, “I admire it.”

“Awww, thanks, babe.” Double Trouble pressed a kiss to her cheek and her ears went red. “You really should pay more attention to the fine print, you know. That could make or break a deal.”

Cainabeth rolled her eyes. “You’re right, I should listen to youâ€”and that’s the worst part.”

â€”

“You told me there would be food,” Cainabeth said crossly, as Double Trouble picked up the most expensive-looking refreshment at the table.

“There is food, darling.” Double Trouble raised their eyebrows as they took a bite.

“I can’t eat it, dumbass!”

“God, it is no one’s fault that you only eat decaying carcasses!” They rolled their eyes, resuming their place next to Cainabeth, who sniffed derisively. “Bitch.”

“Love you too, babeâ€”” They stopped as their leg collided with something: no, someone. Pressing their hand to their hip, they scoffed, “Ugh! Excuse me, who are you?”

“Some nerve saying that shit when you’re not supposed to be here,” Cainabeth muttered under her breath, then scowled as Double Trouble hit her in the side to get her to shut up.

“Hello,” warbled the person Trouble had bumped into. The figure was short in stature but long in purple hair that trailed behind them on the ground. Oh, Trouble would kill for that volume. It seemed wasted on this person, however, who had evidently attended a once-a-decade ball in a grease-stained work outfit.

Double Trouble couldn’t appraise the stranger’s look for too long, however, since they’d now decided to botherâ€”sorry, investigate, Cainabeth. “Your wings are very large compared to your body! Ohhh, I’ve never seen anyone with wings this big before!” The stranger clicked a button on a recording device wrapped in theirâ€¦ hair. “Princess Prom log, hour 1.13! This could be my first and possibly only chance to study a member of species Gymnogyps californianus, the elusive species native to outskirts of the Crimson Waste desert, with rare and limited contact with the rest of the kingdomsâ€”” The stranger leaned in to touch one of Cainabeth’s feathers with another strand of prehensile hair. “Fascinating!”

“Hey!” Cainabeth barked, pulling Double Trouble closer to her side. “Don’t touch my fucking wings!” Double Trouble felt her hand press over their hip, and smirked, popping one of their heels off the ground. I knew that protective side would fly out eventually. Meanwhile, Cainabeth tried to shoo the stranger away like they were a mite.

The purple-haired person blinked at them, then spoke into their recorder againâ€”“Subject is non-compliant. According to the laboratory consent protocol Bow coercively implemented on my studies, I now must cease operations.”

“Laboratoryâ€¦ you a scientist?” Cainabeth asked, with narrowed eyes. Double Trouble rolled their eyes and planted their cheek on her shoulder, resigned to listening to a conversation full of bio-jargon.

“Ah, yes!” The short person giggled, and, using their hair, pulled themself up to stand at eye level with Cainabeth. “I’m Princess Entrapta of Dryl! She/her, and pleasure to make your acquaintance!” She offered her hair to shake. Cainabeth recoiled at first, but took it with only a minimal level of confusion.

“Ah, I know you! Never seen your face, only read your papers. Not exactly my field, but I’d have to be a fucking idiot to not care about the work you’ve done with First Ones tech.”

“Oooooh, you want to talk about First Ones tech? Ask me anything!”

Cainabeth straightened, a sparkle in her eye. “I’m Dr. Cainabeth Rot, and I’m a she, by the wayâ€””

“Oh my God,” Double Trouble said, but the two women were already lost in a conversation that they fully didn’t comprehend. They’d have been happy to let the scientists chat, but they saw Devena across the room, and gripped Cainabeth’s arm in veiled excitement. “Cainabeth. Cainabeth! Cainey?”

“Your lizard is calling you,” noted Entrapta. Double Trouble scoffed at this designation, but at least it got Cainabeth to pay attention to them. “The fuck you want?” she growled, the professional excitement fading as quickly as it had emerged.

“We have someone toâ€¦ talk to.” Acutely feeling Entrapta’s eyes on them, they pointed their tail in the wrong direction. Cainabeth rolled her eyes.

“Mmm, okay! Bye!” Entrapta waved as Double Trouble led Cainabeth away.

“Which one againâ€¦?” Cainabeth muttered, eyeing a group of girls.

“Just follow my lead, darling. See how a born thespian does it.”

“You are so conceited I actually might puke, and I eat rotting corpses.”

“I’ll take that as a compliment.” Double Trouble adjusted the buttons on Cainabeth’s coat and looped their arm through hers again. They sauntered up to Devena and her new girlfriend, plastering a smile on their face. “Why, hello, Devena! Didn’t expect to see you here,” they drawled.

“Dumbass, why would a princess not be at the Princess Prom?” Cainabeth muttered in Trouble’s ear. She quickly got elbowed.

Luckily, Devena didn’t hear. She turned away from the other girls, brows knitted. “Double Trouble? Why are you here?”

“Aw, can’t a girl enjoy a party for the sake of it?” they crooned.

The woman beside Devena furrowed her brow. “Darling, who is this?”

Double Trouble’s smile was a little bit strained now. Oh, and now you’re calling her ‘darling’? You just started dating. Devena didn’t call me ‘babe’ for weeks!

“Umâ€¦” Devena cringed. Double Trouble smirked. Make that bitch suffer!

“Devena, who is this?” the girlfriend (Merlot?) whispered.

Devena laid a hand, placating, on her arm. “They’reâ€¦ my ex. Double Trouble. Trouble, this is myâ€¦ new girlfriend, Marlow.”

Damn it! Marlow! I was close.

“Well, you moved on real quickly,” sniffed Marlow, looking Double Trouble up and down. Her nose wrinkled with the obvious assessment of hooker and Trouble immediately wanted to kill this person.

“I mean, I could say the same to you!” Double Trouble said, looking at Devena. “Well, where are my manners? I’d like to introduce you all to Dr. Cainabeth Rot.” Their arm snaked behind her neck, fingertips dropping down to the treacherously low neckline of her dress. Cainabeth smiled, the wicked glint in her eye making Devena stiffen and Marlow take a step back. She pressed a kiss to Double Trouble’s jawlineâ€”which was off-script, but they’d absolutely take it. “Hey.” Her voice was gravelly and her breath smelled like rotten flesh, which definitely made the right audience swoon and normal people recoil.

Awkward silence stretched between them before Devena said woodenly, “Umâ€¦ maybe we should go.”

“Oh, I’ll see you around, Devvy!” Double Trouble waved cheerfully. “Sure nice to see you, though. I hope we can still be friends too, just like you said in that note that you left on your pillow the night you left me!” They swept off with Cainabeth in tow, as they heard Marlow whisper behind them, “A note? Seriously? And you left in the middle of the night?”

“Listen, babe, it’s not what it sounds likeâ€””

Double Trouble snickered when they were out of earshot. “Oh, frabjous day. Nothing better than the look of terror in an ex-girlfriend’s eyes when she sees me.”

“Have you considered that you’re the problem?” Cainabeth groused. “Also, that was the most stressful experience of my fucking life.”

“Honestly, Cainey? You were such a natural!” They lifted their hand to the heavens. “Such a convincing performanceâ€”anyone would have believed it.”

“Whatâ€”fucking performance?” Cainabeth asked, her words breaking into a disbelieving laugh. “I just said ‘hey’!”

“Acting is about more than just the lines, darling. Your stage presenceâ€”your flow, it was beautiful. And that kiss, oh! I love when my actors go off-script just a little!”

Cainabeth’s eyes slid to the side. “Sure. All a part of the show.”

The two of them startled as Princess Frosta’s voice boomed, “It is my solemn duty as hostess to now announce: It is time for the first dance of the ball.” Applause rose up around them as Princesses rushed to the dance floor. Double Trouble smiled and held out their hand.

“Ugh, really? I can’t dance,” Cainabeth tried, but Double Trouble grabbed her hand anyway.

“You scared, Cainey?” Trouble teased. “Just follow my lead.”

Cainabeth nodded, swallowing. She turned her eyes downwards.

“Thisâ€¦ is kind of fun,” she admitted, in the same tone of voice as one says, There’s a roach in my food.

“Is it, darling?” They smiled. “Well, I thought you hated me! Wouldn’t you hate dancing with me, too?”

“I still hate you. I guess I kind of like you sometimes too, though.” They were closer together now, faces inches away. Double Trouble could have licked her if they wanted to. “Hey, that stuff you said about not having any dirt on me. I, uh, appreciate it. I assumed you would, I thought you were that scummy. Mutually assured destruction, I guess. Wasn’t that the deal? I could kill you in a fraction of a second, but you could ruin my entire goddamn life posthumously. I don’t know. I kind of fucking hate it. Miss me with that psychological warfare shit. It’s not humane, is it? I think I’d prefer to get my guts ripped out. But anyway, what have you got on me if not blackmail?”

“Oh, all manner of things. Of course, I’ve got the stuff I know from ourâ€¦ more intimate encounters that would absolutely destroy your reputation. Now, the more serious things I ruin your life with don’t have to be true, they just have to be convincing. I’m fortunate that you have no friends or living family that would try to refute you. It’d be my word against yours, and I have many, many contacts. I’m confident I could dream up something noxious that everyone will believe, maybe even you. I know you well enough to get under your skinâ€”I know how you work. Who knows? The slander might even be true if I predict it well enough.”

Cainabeth’s shoulders relaxed. “Ugh. It makes me feel so much better knowing you’re not just staying with me for the hell of it. Thanks for having ulterior motives. You’re a great friend.”

“I don’t think you understand what friendship is.”

“I get it more than you,” Cainabeth snarled. “You just sell yourself off to the highest bidder.”

Double Trouble stopped in their tracks, but she was gone, sweeping off to the next dance partner. They were face-to-face with someone that had dark skin and shiny blue hair, who looked as if they wanted nothing to do with anybody at this party. That had to be Mermista, the Princess of Salineas.

“Hey, darling,” Double Trouble said, smiling.

“Oh my God, you too? Sea Hawk is enough. Uuuuuggghhhhh,” complained Mermista, her groan audible even as she pulled away. Double Trouble looked around, searching for Cainabeth in the crowd. Their next partner was short and pink, with two buns on the sides of their head. They smiled, cheerily, if a bit uneasy. Double Trouble lifted their partner up, straining with the effortâ€”they were surprisingly heavy for their small size. Setting them down, Double Trouble quickly spun away, touching hands with Cainabeth again.

“Hey, fucker,” the condor whispered, her voice raspy, leaning in. Her musky scent enveloped Double Trouble. The black leather of her glove pressed against their bare waist.

“And here I thought you didn’t know how to dance.”

“Well, I may have picked up a few things.” Cainabeth spun Double Trouble around, then pulled them in close, their hips banging together.

Then, without warning, she swept them low in a dip. Her wings were spread out behind her and her gloved hand was on the small of their back, pressing against the base of Double Trouble’s tail and pushing a hitch into their breath.

“Maybe you haveâ€¦” they said, breaking out into a wicked grin. Cainabeth lifted them up again, their faces close together.

“Fuck this,” she whispered, pressing her mouth messily to Double Trouble’s cheek and inhaling. “I wanna get out of here.”

“You and me both, darling,” Trouble murmured, pushing their head against her neck and resting a hand on her chest. The two of them made their way to the edge of the dance floor, and Double Trouble held out their hand. Cainabeth roughly grabbed the ring on their choker instead, prompting a giggle.

Screaming and crashing sounded from the other side of the dance floor. Cainabeth moved in close to Double Trouble’s side. “What was that?”

“Well, someone took advantage of all the Princesses being gathered up in one location,” Double Trouble muttered, examining their nails.

An angry blonde yelled at a magicat. The words weren’t important, but they certainly were making a spectacle of themselves, as the blonde lifted the cat by the collar.

“Looks like Horde bullshit.”

“Ugh, I really do not have time for all this nonsense.”

Cainabeth rolled her eyes. “For real. Come on, there’s way more fun things we could be looking at.” She scowled as the blonde was suddenly encased in magical ice.

“I hereby revoke your invitation!” Frosta’s voice rang out, defiant.

“Ouch,” Double Trouble said, relish in their voice. “That’s really gotta hurtâ€”“

They were cut off by the sound of explosions, and they reflexively ducked, shielding their head. Reaching under their skirt, they pulled out their thin dagger from their thigh holster. Beside them, Cainabeth’s eyes widened, wings immediately flaring out behind her. “What?!” The talons hidden in her gloves slid out with a click.

“Well, this wasn’t supposed to happen,” Double Trouble said, dryly, holding their knife in a crouch.

“We need to get the fuck out of hereâ€”!” Cainabeth grunted as party guests shoved her left and right. Growling in rage, she rushed to Double Trouble, shielding them with her wings.

“Hey, you’re not supposed to have weapons in here, the fuck?”

“First of all, your gloves are way deadlier. Second of all, neither of us are supposed to be here either, and third of all, there’s fucking explosions happening and we have bigger problems!”

“Just cut to the chase when you say something, you stupid gay bitch!” Cainabeth picked up Double Trouble easily and got a running start, lifting off the ground and soaring under the high ceilings of the icy palace. She wove through the iridescent pillars, then dove to clear the archway and escape into the frosty night.

In the air, Double Trouble caressed Cainabeth’s face. “Did you have fun?”

“I came here because of you, and you fucking lied to me about there being food, so I just stood around awkward and hungry and pretending I was your girlfriend to your stupid ex.” She paused for a little bit too long. “It was kinda fun fucking with you, though.”

A safe distance away from the palace, she landed, setting Double Trouble gently down. They winced at the even more frigid temperatures, and she wrapped her wings around them, trying to keep them warm. “It’s okay.” Her body was ridiculously hot where it touched theirs, and against their will, they pressed closer, against Cainabeth’s bare chest. “Okay, look, the hotel’s not far from here, and we’ll be on the transport back home first thing in the morning.”

She says home so easily. Like she’s planning on staying there forever, Double Trouble thought. “Oh, what would I ever do without you?”

Cainabeth shrugged, simply, locking their arms together. “You’d probably survive. I don’t think anyone could kill you even if they tried really fucking hard. You’re like a cockroach.”

“Aw, thanks, doc. That was almost a compliment! You’re getting there.”

“Shut the fuck up.”

“Or you’ll eat me, huh?”

“Actually, on second thought, I think you’d taste fucking horrible.”

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